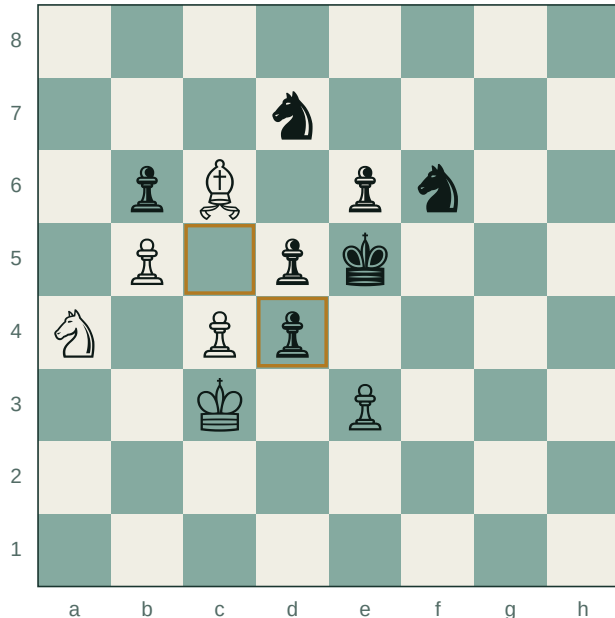


Capture the defender: White, move 36

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 35...cxd4+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

36. exd4+ Kd6 37. Bxd7 Kxd7 38. Nxb6+ Kc7 39. c5

36.exd4+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on d4. Recorded reply: **36...Kd6**.

37.Bxd7 The bishop captures the knight on d7. Recorded reply: **37...Kxd7**.

38.Nxb6+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on b6. Recorded reply: **38...Kc7**.

39.c5 The pawn moves from c4 to c5.

At the end, nominal material is White 6 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from -1 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e5. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.